

Beyond launch services, Agnikul plans to evolve into a full-stack space company by expanding into satellite propulsion services. The company sees significant opportunity in the underserved small satellite launch market, where customers often face delays, higher costs and compromises when flying as secondary payloads on larger rockets.

ETHEREALX (ETHEREAL EXPLORATION GUILD)

A T 27, MANU J. NAIR, Co-founder and CEO, EtherealX, is attempting something few aerospace companies in the world have dared to pursue: building a fully reusable medium-lift rocket capable of competing with SpaceX's Falcon 9-class launch vehicles. Founded in 2022, the start-up grew out of an informal dinner conversation between Nair and his co-founders Shubhayu Sardar and Prashanth Sharma. "I was supposed to move to the US, Prashanth had an offer from Rocket Lab, and Shubhayu was in ISRO where I had joined as a project associate right out of college for a brief six-month stint. The dinner conversation was about access to orbit still being a luxury. We went down that rabbit hole of why it was the case and found out that most were building small rockets while the market was shifting towards larger constellations," Nair tells *BT*.

Reusable medium-lift rockets offered far greater economic advantages than small launchers. "From a customer perspective, satellite operators would ideally have most of their constellations go up in a single go rather than paying a higher cost per kg in a smaller rocket and doing multiple launches. We realised that the single advantage of a small rocket was that it could be launched on demand or frequently. But that advantage was only relevant until reusability was not there in the picture. When reusability came into existence, the frequency advantage got wiped away," says Nair.

However, replicating SpaceX's model was impossible due to its vertically integrated operations, Starlink revenues, government contracts, and massive manufacturing scale.

"That's when we realised that if there has to be another successful launch company, then you should be able to operate in this class of payload while retaining the cost and frequency advantage," says Nair.

While Skyroot and Agnikul are working in small



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satellite rocket segments, EtherealX's rockets will have a 20-tonne capacity, the same as SpaceX's Falcon 9 Class. "Differentiating us from SpaceX will be full-stack reusability," says Nair.

But there are challenges. "The infrastructure for testing rocket engines is not there."

EtherealX aims to launch its first rocket by February 2028. In January 2026, Ethereal Exploration Guild (EtherealX) announced a \$20.5 million Series A funding round.